

SAFETY, REPORTING & PROTECTION

Vimbiso

A WhatsApp-first risk-triage tool that responds to a survivor the moment she reports — no waiting, no second report required.

OSF / Andela Hackathon · Kenya Pilot · Tendai Moyo & Nnouka

A documented crisis — and a live transparency failure

220

femicides documented
in Kenya in 2025

129

in Q1 2025 alone —
roughly one a day

1,069

women killed,
2016–2025

The Kenyan government stopped publishing femicide data after March 2025.

That's not just a severity statistic — it's a live, current trust and transparency failure. A survivor today has less official visibility into this crisis than a survivor had a year ago.

The mechanism most pitches get wrong

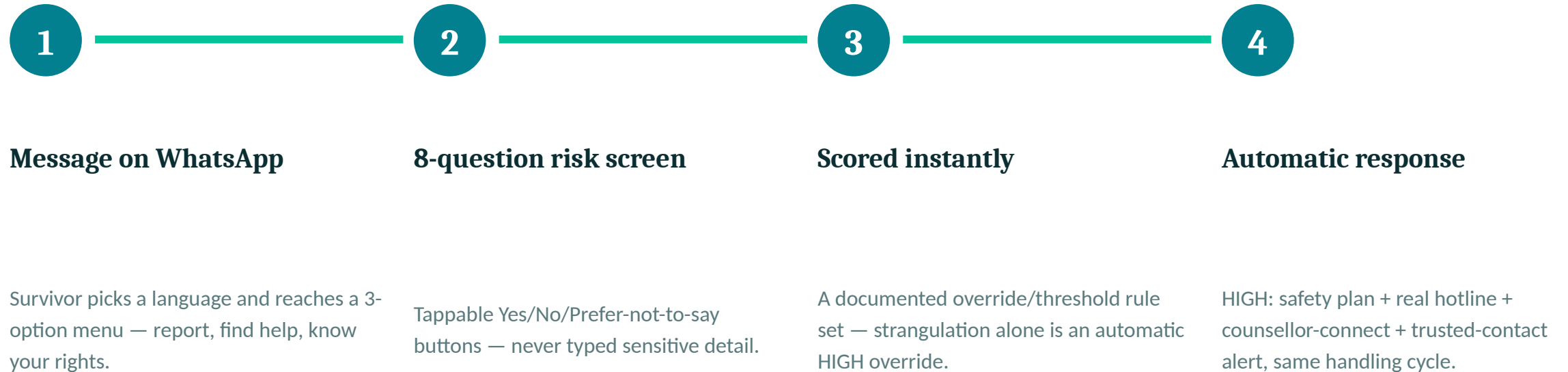
Our first design

- A "matching-escrow" model: a survivor's report only became visible once a second, independent report named the same perpetrator.
- Modeled on real evidence from Cameroon's femicide pattern — but real cases show a first report can be the last chance to help someone.
- Waiting for corroboration before responding is a fatal design flaw for a HIGH-risk case.

What we corrected it to

- Risk-triage first: every report runs through an 8-question screen based on documented lethality-risk factors.
- A single HIGH-risk report triggers an immediate, automatic safety response — no second person, no waiting.
- Pattern-matching across reports still exists — demoted to a non-urgent, consent-gated "Pattern Watch" feature, never the primary safety path.

One report. One response. No waiting.



Real evidence this sprint: a live HIGH-risk journey run against a real Postgres database completed the full sequence — safety plan, real-code SMS alert, trusted-contact check-in, Pattern Watch match — within one handling cycle, in both English and Swahili.

Trust is the whole track — so privacy isn't a feature, it's the architecture



No legal-name field, anywhere

reports and trusted_contacts have no name/legal_name/id_number column — confirmed by direct schema inspection, not just design intent.



A perpetrator is hashed, never named

HMAC-SHA256, salted — a live audit searched every text column in every table and found zero raw text outside the intended hash.



Every cross-report action is consent-gated

perpetrator_consent_given and wants_counsellor_connect default false — verified: no hash row, no SMS, unless the survivor explicitly said yes.



Anonymous by default, reversible only by lawful process

Message-analysis logging pseudonymizes senders with a one-way hash no key can reverse — a separate, custodian-held key (never in normal app config) allows lawful re-identification via a standalone script, and every use is audit-logged. Built and verified end-to-end against a real database.

Language coverage — stated exactly as built, not as planned

Language	Tier	Keys	What's actually covered
English	FULL	87	Every user-facing string in the product.
Swahili	PARTIAL, unreviewed	11	Only the safety-critical HR-1 sequence + Pattern Watch consent. Everything else falls back to English.
French	PARTIAL, unreviewed	11	Same safety-critical subset. Nnouka (native speaker, core team) has committed to reviewing it.
Arabic / Kinyarwanda	Architecture-only	0	Schema supports adding these instantly — no content drafted yet; contingent on volunteer reviewers.

A language never claims more completeness than it has: content_strings carries its own tier column, and the code logs — and falls back to English — the instant a key is missing.

What's real, and what's honestly still simulated

Real

- Full conversation state machine, risk scoring, and hashing — real code
- Real local Postgres database: migrations, seeds, and 5 full conversation journeys actually executed
- Live SQL-level verification of every dashboard query and a full privacy audit

Still simulated

- No live Twilio WhatsApp Sandbox round-trip yet — sandboxed dev environment has no outbound Twilio access
- No real SMS has reached a real phone yet — the SMS code path is real, the network call is captured, not sent
- Dashboard EJS rendering not yet run — no express/ejs install available here; verified at the query layer instead

Full accounting: [docs/qa-sprint3-report.md](#) and [README.md](#) §Real vs. simulated.

Why Kenya — a real comparison, not a default

1

Strongest, most current data

Kenya's crisis data is the most multi-sourced of the countries compared (Zimbabwe, Cameroon, Rwanda, Tanzania) — and the government's own publishing gap makes the transparency case immediate.

2

A real institution to hand off to

HAK/1195 is a dedicated, UN-backed, actively-promoted national toll-free GBV helpline — makes "connect me to a counsellor" credible, not aspirational.

3

An actual hackathon community

Kenya (@KEN) is a real participating Andela chapter, alongside Cameroon (@CMR) and Rwanda (@RWA) — a concrete channel for translation reviewers, not cold outreach.

Honestly weighed against: Cameroon's data was the reason risk-triage became our core mechanism — but weak routing infrastructure there means Vimbisio, a “smart front door,” has no reliable door to stand in front of yet.

Built by a team with lived, not theoretical, reach

Tendai Moyo

Harare-based civic-tech founder, native Shona speaker.

Leads product and the original Zimbabwe-origin research that shaped the risk-triage design; drove the pitch, deck, video, and reviewer coordination.

Nnouka

Cameroonian, based at CMU Africa in Kigali, working with Andela. Fluent English / French / Pidgin.

Leads the French-language build and review as a native speaker and core team member — the same market whose femicide data corrected our core safety mechanism during development. Also coordinating a Kinyarwanda lead through Kigali networks.

Phase 2 roadmap

Live Twilio deployment

A real WhatsApp Sandbox round-trip and real SMS delivery — the one gap this sandboxed build cannot close on its own.

Real translation review

Swahili and French moved from PARTIAL/unreviewed to FULL/reviewed via @KEN and Nnouka's own review.

Cameroon & Rwanda expansion

Once real institutional GBV-response partnerships exist to hand survivors off to — not before.

USSD / low-bandwidth channel

Serves the ~60% of Kenyans not yet online — reframed as inclusion, not the pitch's central differentiator.

A single report is enough.

Vimbiso responds the moment someone reaches out — with a real safety plan, a real hotline, and a real path to a counsellor. Built honestly: every claim in this deck is backed by real code, a real database, and a documented source.

[github.com/\[org\]/vimbiso](#) · [docs/qa-sprint3-report.md](#) · [docs/mvp-spec.md](#)